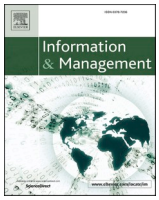
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How do influencers' impression management tactics affect purchase intention in live commerce? – Trust transfer and gender differences

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ABSTRACT

Influencers in live commerce play a pivotal role in guiding consumers' purchase decisions. Prior studies have explored how influencers' different characteristics impact consumers' purchase intention in live commerce. Nevertheless, the role of influencers' impression management strategies in this context remains a largely unexplored terrain. We draw on the impression management lens and integrate the stimulus-organism-response framework together with social role theory to examine a comprehensive research model regarding how influencers' different impression management tactics (i.e., self-focused, consumer-focused, and product-focused impression management tactics) affect trust perceptions, which further contribute to female and male consumers' purchase intention in live commerce. We first conducted a qualitative interview (N = 71) to validate the existence of influencers' three impression management tactics, and then designed a scenario-based survey (N = 241) to test the research model. Our study enriches the understanding of impression management tactics in the live commerce context, extends social role theory to explain the different decision pathways of female and male consumers during live shopping, and also offers practical insights for influencers and managers of live commerce platforms.

1. Introduction

Live commerce, or live streaming e-commerce, integrates both elements of live streaming technology and e-commerce and has been enjoying its heyday in the past few years [1,2]. The live commerce transaction volume on Douyin, a highly popular live streaming platform in China, reached RMB 2.7 trillion in 2023 [3]. About 597 million people in China used live commerce by the end of 2023, accounting for around 55 percent of the total Internet users [4]. The live commerce revenue in the United States reached USD 50 billion by the end of 2023 and is expected to exceed USD 68 billion by 2026 [5]. Indeed, a growing number of influencers are turning online traffic in their live accounts into sales through live commerce [6]. Influencers are the streamers sharing their knowledge, opinions, and daily lives to create a particular online persona to attract and retain a stable and large number of followers, and subsequently commercialize such social capital on the live streaming platforms [7,8]. Scholarly investigations have consistently underscored the significance of influencers' online personas during live streaming, revealing that factors such as attractiveness, speaking style, and other individual traits profoundly impact viewer attitudes [9,10]. Recent reports also indicated that impressions are one of the main tools for measuring the effectiveness of influencers [11]. Although up to 80 % of marketers believe that influencers have prominent impacts on unlocking consumers purchases [12], influencers themselves still face the challenge that their self-presentations in live streaming channels cannot always attract and retain expected fans volume and realize benefits [13]. Therefore, how to strategically present online images to effectively capitalize visits on live streaming platforms has been a key issue for influencers and managers of live commerce, as well as for researchers.

Proper impression management tactics not only help influencers establish harmonious relationships with consumers, but also build competitive advantages in the online market [14,15]. However, the extant studies typically approach the practical query of how to grow business in live commerce through the theoretical perspectives that have been used in traditional e-commerce or social commerce settings, for example, the match-up among seller, consumer, and product [6,9],

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information processing theory [10,16], technology affordance theory [17–19], and flow theory [20,21]. While these perspectives provide valuable insights, they may not fully capture the nuanced dynamics of live commerce—a distinct paradigm that diverges significantly from traditional e-commerce. Traditional e-commerce primarily relies on static images and textual descriptions to showcase product information, whereas live commerce harnesses the power of live streaming technology to provide a comprehensive and dynamic product demonstration. Live commerce allows streamers to synchronously present products from multiple perspectives, offering viewers an immersive and interactive shopping experience. As such, we maintain that the key element that differentiates live commerce from other e-commerce settings is influencers' instant demonstration of all aspects of themselves together with their products for sale, but limited research efforts have been devoted in this regard. Toward this end, our study attempts to investigate consumers' purchase decisions in live commerce through the lens of influencers' impression management behaviors.

Impression management means that individuals attempt to create and manage their desired images in view of others [22], and such impression management can be accomplished through either people- or task-focused tactics [23,24]. Many studies have explored the role of influencers' own characteristics in view of consumers, such as attractiveness [9], expertise [20,25], and trustworthiness [10], in leading to purchase behaviors. Other studies pay attention to influencers' responsive characteristics toward consumers, such as friendliness [25], responsiveness [21], and interactivity and personalization [19]. No studies so far have attempted to theoretically differentiate and juxtapose self- and consumer-focused impression management behaviors in live commerce. Moreover, impression management tactics can also be task-focused [23,24]. Given that live streaming serves as the only channel for influencers to communicate and for consumers to diagnose product information [26], such an impression management tactic with a focus on product live demonstration also worth research efforts. Therefore, our research questions include (1) *what are the impression management tactics employed by influencers in the context of live commerce,* and (2) *how do these tactics differentially influence consumers' purchase intention?*

Impression management can adopt either a people-focused or a task-focused approach, as highlighted by previous research [23,24]. In the context of live commerce, two primary personas emerge—the live streamers who promote products and the consumers who make purchase decisions; the primary task in this scenario is the purchase of products. Consequently, we identify three influencers' impression management tactics in the live commerce context, namely, self-, consumer-, and product-focused presentation. For example, influencers can engage in self-focused presentation, positioning themselves as professionals in a certain domain, say, cosmetics, and selling related products such as lipsticks and eyebrow pencils. Influencers can leverage the instant communication tools of voices and bullet features to carefully respond to every single query from consumers, that is, consumer-focused presentation. Influencers can also perform product-focused presentation, spending much effort to demonstrate detailed functionalities of their products in live shows.

In particular, we refer to the stimulus-organism-response (S-O-R) framework as the overarching theory to understand how the three influencers' impression management tactics influence the purchase intention. The S-O-R framework emphasizes environmental stimuli can influence an individual's cognitive and affective perceptions, which consequently evoke behavioral intentions [27]. As mentioned previously, the most salient characteristic of live commerce is the real-time demonstration of influencers, presenting themselves in front of viewers as potential consumers as well as the products they promote. Such people- and task-focused presentations by influencers serve as a direct stimulus attracting viewers to watch live streaming, believe in influencers together with the products they sell, and engage in live shopping. In other words, influencers' impression management tactics first impact the viewers' cognitive and emotional evaluations of the influencer and their products, and ultimately shape the purchase decisions. Therefore, the S-O-R framework is a parsimonious yet structured theoretical model helping us understand how the stimuli rooted in influencers' versatile presentation tactics (S) arouse their psychological state (O), thereby driving purchase behaviors (R) in live commerce.

Moreover, trust is a well-established construct that scholars used to explain the most critical psychological state underlying many transaction behaviors, both offline [28,29] and online [30,31]. Scholars emphasize the pivotal role of trust in business transactions, given the absence of trust often leads to transaction failures [1]. While prior studies have highlighted the significance of flow [32], psychological proximity [21], or immersion [33] as important psychological states when viewers engage in watching live streaming, we maintain that trust still serves as the most paramount psychological factor contributing to economic behaviors in such immersive settings [19,34]. In particular, both streamers and products are two important reference objects when consumers make purchase decisions. That is, consumers' purchase decisions depend on their perceptions of both product quality as well as streamers' trustworthiness [19,35]. Nevertheless, there are still limited insights available regarding how the two trust perceptions would function differentially across diverse population groups. Consequently, we propose a nuanced theoretical distinction between trust in influencers and trust in products, highlighting them as the differential psychological mechanisms underlying buyer-seller and buyer-product exchanges, respectively, in live commerce. Moreover, we incorporate social role theory to further delineate the nuanced functional differences between the two trust perceptions across female and male consumers.

The S-O-R framework indeed serves as a valuable overarching lens for understanding consumers' behaviors in live commerce. Nevertheless, the S-O-R framework per se cannot effectively capture how diverse population groups respond differentially toward a number of external stimuli. Taking together that the two trust perceptions might also function differently across diverse consumer groups, we refer to social role theory [36] and make sense of the boundary condition of gender in live commerce. Gender is an important demographic factor in both technology use and social commerce literature. Women and men behave with different orientations in technology use in general and in online shopping in particular. Women tend to care more about social and communal relations, and men are more oriented toward utilitarian motives when using social media [37–39]. During live stream shopping, a majority percentage of women would purchase experience products such as cosmetics, fragrances, and personal care, while more than half of men intend to buy electronic products that are searchable through standard specifications [40]. Female consumers' purchase decisions tend to be motivated by their empathy and feelings toward streamers' shows, but male ones are sensitive to rational and systematic elaborations thus care more about products' functional features [18]. Hence, we expect that the influential mechanisms of trust in influencers and trust in products also work differentially for men and women in live commerce.

To summarize, our research makes the following contributions. First, our study offers a novel impression management perspective unveiling the underlying motivation of consumers' purchase behaviors in live commerce and innovatively categorizing three influencers' impression management tactics—self-focused, consumer-focused, and product-focused presentation tactics. Second, we differentiate between trust in influencers and trust in products in live commerce and uncover that female and male consumers react differently to different trust perceptions when making purchase decisions in live shopping. As such, our research deepens the knowledge of trust-building processes across female and male consumers in live commerce. Finally, our study also offers inspiration to both influencers and managers on boosting live commerce sales through various impression management tactics.

2. Literature review

The stimulus-organism-response (S-O-R) framework from environmental psychology explains how environmental cues function on individuals' reactive feelings and behaviors [27]. Specifically, various aspects of external environment (S) affect individuals' innate cognitive and affective states (O), which are subsequently manifested in their behaviors (R) [41]. The S-O-R framework has been applied to understand purchase decisions and behaviors in both the traditional and new emerging e-commerce contexts. For instance, Tang and Zhang [42] examined how three types of atmospheric cues (task, aesthetic, and social cues) (S) offer utilitarian, hedonic, and connective affordances (O), thereby impacting consumers' approach intention to stay in shopping websites and avoidance intentions (R) to move away from it in social commerce. Similarly, Chopdar and Balakrishnan [43] found that contextual offering, visual attractiveness, and mobile app incentives (S) affect consumers' impulsiveness and perceived value (O), which further influence purchase intention (R) in mobile commerce.

Likewise, in the context of live commerce, influencers' demonstration and presentation from various aspects serve as the key stimulus affecting consumers' purchase decisions. For example, Hu & Chaudhry [44] investigated how influencers' relational bonds with viewers (S) nurture affective commitment (O), thereby improving consumer engagement (R). [158] observed that influencers' expertise, similarity, familiarity, and likeability (S) are essential stimuli that enhance their swift *guanxi* with potential consumers (O), a quickly formed interpersonal relationship between buyers and sellers in the online marketplace. Such swiftly created guanxi, in turn, promotes consumers' purchase intentions (R). The unique feature that sets live commerce apart from other e-commerce settings is its ability to enable influencers to display products, demonstrate their expertise and goodwill, and interact with consumers in real time. In the eye of consumers, how influencers demonstrate products, themselves, and in response to viewers through the live channel is the most direct stimulus factors that drive consumers' attitudes and willingness to make purchases. Therefore, we consider the S-O-R framework to be a suitable overarching theory that helps us understand how influencers' different impression management tactics (S) play a role in nurturing buyers' trust perceptions (O) and in turn motivating buyers' purchase behaviors (R) in live commerce.

2.1. Influencers' impression management tactics in live commerce

Impression management is universal among interpersonal encounters, in which people consciously manage their images in the view of others to achieve personal goals [22,45]. The impression management lens has been extensively applied to explain organizational behaviors, consumer behaviors, as well as technology use behaviors (see the second column of research context in Table 1). For instance, management scholars draw on impression management theory to understand supervisors' performance ratings of followers [160] and group cohesion and vitality [46] in the organizational context. Marketing scholars also refer to the impression management lens to explain consumers' luxury products purchase behaviors in the offline market places [47]. Information systems scholars take impression management perspective to investigate the maintenance and development of networks in both hedonic and enterprise social media settings [48,49], trust and satisfaction with the metaverse usage [50], and patient choices of physicians in online health platforms [159]. However, this insightful theoretical lens is yet to be extended into the live commerce context and explain how influencers' statements and behaviors in live commerce display nuanced impacts on consumers' purchase behaviors.

Impression management tactics can be either people- or task-focused [23,24]. In the impression management process, individuals, or "actors, " present themselves based on the expectations or preferences of their "audiences" [22]. Those who purposefully present themselves are considered "actors," while those who consume these purposeful presentations are regarded as "audiences." As such, impression management tactics focus on either the individuals presenting themselves (the "actors") or the people they are trying to influence (the "audiences"). Scholars have proposed a similar taxonomy of impression management tactics that focus on people involved in social encounters, for example, self-presentation versus other enhancement [51–53] and self-promotion versus ingratiation [54]. For another, impression management tactics can also be tailored to a specific task to be performed, for example, job

Table 1
Literature on impression management.

Study	Research context	Research phenomenon	Sample	Method	Findings
Bande Vilela et al., [160]	Sales organization	Salesperson's performance rating from supervisors	122 salespeople and their immediate managers from 35 firms	Survey	Supervisor-focused impression management was positively related to the supervisor's liking of the salesperson but work-focused tactics was not significantly related to liking.
Pan et al., [46]	Online community	Group cohesion and vitality of online communities	Study 1: 418 university students in Beijing Study 2: 480 university students in Beijing	Survey, experiment	Group impression management can effectively improve group trust, reduce group privacy concerns, and enhance group cohesion and vitality.
Sun et al., [49]	Enterprise social media platforms	Employees' impression management strategies on enterprise social media	80 articles	Literature review	ESMPs' affordances directly affect employees' impression management strategies, and indirectly promote it through network characteristics, psychological outcomes, and negative outcomes.
Ouyang et al., [159]	Online health community	Patients' choices of physicians in the online health community	47,481 physicians' images and other related information from Haodf.com	Econometric model	A physician's beauty or physical attractiveness has no significant effect on patients' choice; Smile has a positive effect on patients' choices; physician's skin status also positively affects patients' choices.
Schiller et al., [50]	Metaverse	Trust and satisfaction in virtual collaboration team	432 graduate students enrolled in an MIS course	A blocked design	Impression management has a significant association with team solution satisfaction for male dyads only. Impression management is the key factor associated with trust in same-gender dyads but not in mixed-gender dyads.
Kim & Liu, [48]	Social media	Micro-celebrities' self-presentation on social media	3627 photos from 117 micro-celebrities accounts on Instagram	Content analysis	Three self-presentation strategies are adopted by micro-celebrities on Instagram: Authenticity, self-promotion, and affiliation strategy; self-presentation strategies vary by gender and account types of micro-celebrities.
Rosendo-Rios & Shukla, [47]	Luxury goods market	Luxury purchase intentions	Study 1: 202 traditional Spanish luxury consumers; Study 2: 205 respondents from the Prolific Academic panel.	Survey, experiment	Instrumental self-presentation helps to mitigate the negative effects of luxury democratization on luxury product purchase intentions.

performance. Wayne and Ferris [55] classified three types of impression management tactics in organizations, including self-focused, supervisor-focused, and job-focused. Job-focused impression management tactics in particular capture employees' statements or behaviors about the tasks to be performed at job [55].

In the live commerce context, influencers leverage various live-streaming technology features to create appealing online images and attract followers to purchase products from them [56]. Accordingly, we follow the prior insights and classify influencers' impression management tactics in live commerce into people- and task-focused ones, including self-focused presentation, consumer-focused presentation, and product-focused presentation. Specifically, self-focused presentation refers to influencers' showing themselves favorably and competently, for example, a warm-hearted person, a sincere person, or a capable person [55,57]. Consumer-focused presentation involves influencers' statements and behaviors that are responsive to consumers' needs or interests, making them feel like the center of attention [55]. Product-focused presentation refers to influencers' demonstrating product functions appealingly, so as to help consumers have an in-depth understanding of product values [55,58].

We also carefully scrutinize the extant live commerce literature (see Table 2) and identify the following research gaps. First, the extant live commerce studies pay attention to either influencers' characteristics (see the fourth column of antecedents in Table 2), such as attractiveness [9,10], expertise [20,25], and trustworthiness [10], or their response characteristics to consumers, such as friendliness [25], responsiveness [21], likability [158] and personalization [19], to explain and predict purchase intentions and behaviors. As mentioned, impression management tactics entail both people- and task-focused ones. In live commerce settings, influencers' people-focused impression management tactics center upon not only themselves but also consumers, and task-focused tactics mainly refer to product live demonstration content. Influencers' characteristics belong to self-focused impression management tactics, while their response characteristics can be classified as consumer-focused ones. Therefore, we conclude that the existing research on live commerce only addresses one or two impression management tactics. However, it lacks a comprehensive overview of how different impression management tactics used by influencers would impact consumers' purchasing behaviors.

Moreover, the extant live commerce studies have also examined several psychological mechanisms that transmit the stimulus of live commerce settings into purchase decisions (see the fifth column of psychological mechanism in Table 2), such as trust [17,30], persuasiveness [10], flow [20,21], and proximity [21]. Among these psychological mechanisms, trust is regarded as the most critical mediator that directly connects the live streaming stimuli with consumer behaviors [19], since a lack of trust is often the main cause of failure in live commerce [17]. While trust in general has been well-established in traditional e-commerce environments through escrow services or other institutional mechanisms, consumers still perceive live shopping to be risky due to the instant and impulsive nature of live commerce [16]. Moreover, most studies do not differentiate between the reference objects toward which consumers form their trust perceptions. Only a few studies have attempted to distinguish between trust in influencers and trust in products, but their research models and findings indicate limited theoretical distinctions between the two types of trust. Therefore, in the following, we conceptualize and differentiate between trust in influencers and trust in products.

2.2. Trust perceptions in live commerce

Trust means "a psychological state comprising the intention to accept vulnerability based upon positive expectations of the intentions or behavior of another" ([60], p. 395). Trust is especially an important concept when business activities migrate from offline into the online context [61], representing consumer beliefs that e-tailors will provide truthful information and quality products that meet expectations [62,63]. A high level of trust can reduce consumers' risk and uncertainty perceptions and encourage online purchase intentions and behaviors [63]. Trust continues to be a salient determinant across the emerging e-commerce settings, for example, mobile commerce [64], social commerce [65], virtual reality [66], and voice shopping [67], and has diverged into various types of trust, for example, trust in technology device or platform [68], trust in sellers [69], trust in community members [1], and even trust in products [30]. Trust perceptions nurture consumers' satisfaction with e-tailors [70], e-loyalty [71], stickiness with online stores [72], and e-word-of-mouth [73]. More importantly, trust transfer theory suggests that trust perceptions are transferrable from one type to another [74,75], and quite a few studies have obtained corroborative evidence of trust transfer across different e-commerce contexts [69,76,77]. For example, Zhao et al. [31] find that trust in sellers of online stores is transferred into trust in the brand. Likewise, in live commerce, trust in broadcasters is malleable toward trust in both products and community members [1].

We conceptualize two types of trust perceptions in live commerce, namely trust in influencers and trust in products. Trust in influencers characterizes the exchange in consumer-influencer relationships, whereas trust in products features the exchange in consumer-product relationships. Specifically, trust in influencers represents consumers' beliefs that an influencer is reliable, trustworthy, and honest to them and will not rip off them in online business transactions [30,35]. Trust in influencers entails both a cognitive evaluation of influencers' expertise and competencies and an emotional connection with them [78,79]. Consumers' cognitive assessments of influencers play a crucial role in mitigating perceived risks during business transactions, while emotional bonds serve to diminish the psychological distance between consumers and influencers [79,80]. Trust in products is defined as consumers' confidence that a product will perform following its specifications [30,35]. Analogous to trust in influencers, consumers' perceptions of trust towards products involve a rational evaluation of product functionalities and an emotional attachment to their appearances [30]. Consequently, both trust perceptions in influencers and products encompass cognitive and affective dimensions [79].

Notably, in live commerce settings, alternative forms of trust exist, such as trust in the platform [81], channel trust [34], etc. Since mobile devices and social commerce have become ubiquitous for decades, we do not expect trust in social platforms to exert salient influences in live commerce. Also, influencers outperform virtual stores or digital brands in attracting consumers in live commerce [82], and we do not expect trust perceptions in brands or stores to play a significant role in affecting live commerce sales. Additionally, trust in products is different from product value: trust in products is consumers' subjective perceptions, beliefs, or confidence in product quality that helps reduce uncertainty feelings in online transactions, whereas product value emphasizes a product's expected functional, emotional, and social performances [83]. In live commerce settings, consumers are likely to patronize and stay loyal to stores when they believe influencers are trustworthy and products are reliable.

2.3. Gender differences in live commerce

In addition to the S-O-R framework, we also consider gender differences in understanding how influencers' impression management tactics affect consumers' purchase intentions in live commerce. Social role theory posits that women and men behave differently but in accordance with role expectations and normative beliefs that are construed through socialization processes [36,84]. In other words, gender stereotypes are constructed through different social learning processes according to biological sexes [85]. Generally speaking, women tend to be cooperative, care about intimacy, and are willing to maintain harmonious interpersonal relationships, whereas men are attentive to independence, risks, and competition [86]. Furthermore, women pay

Table 2
Literature on live commerce.

Study	Research phenomena	Theory	Antecedents	Psychological mechanism	Sample	Method	Findings
Hu & Chaudhry, [44]	Consumer engagement	SOR theory	Social bonds, structural bonds, financial bonds	Affective commitment to the broadcaster, affective commitment to the online marketplace	327 Taobao live streaming users	Survey	Financial bonds, social bonds, and structural bonds positively influence consumers' affective commitment, which consequently leads to consumer engagement.
Park & Lin, [6]	Intention to buy	Match-up hypothesis	Wanghong-product fit, live content-product fit, self-product fit	Wanghong trustworthiness, wanghong attractiveness, utilitarian attitude, hedonic attitude	252 participants with live shopping experience	Survey	Wanghong–product fit relates positively to perceived trustworthiness and perceived attractiveness of Wanghong while live content–product fit relates positively to utilitarian attitude and hedonic attitude, which lead to purchase intention.
Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, [30]	Customers' engagement	The model of "shopping value"	Customers' perceived value (utilitarian value, hedonic value, symbolic value)	Customer trust (trust in products, trust in sellers)	261 Bangkok-based respondents	Survey	The utilitarian value and hedonic value of live streaming positively influence customers' trust in the product while the symbolic value positively influence customers' trust in the seller, which lead to customer engagement.
Chen et al., (2021)	Purchase intention	SOR theory	*Perceived expertise, perceived similarity, perceived likeability, perceived familiarity*	Swift guanxi	336 Taobao Live users	Survey	The perceived expertise, similarity, familiarity, and likeability of live streaming sellers positively influence swift guanxi, which further lead to purchase intention in live stream shopping.
Gao et al., [10]	Purchase intention, response intention	Elaboration likelihood model	Central route (information completeness, accuracy, currency); peripheral route (*streamer trustworthiness, attractiveness,* bullet-screen consistency, co-viewer involvement)	Perceived persuasiveness	395 participants with live shopping experience	Survey	Information completeness, information currency, streamer trustworthiness, attractiveness, co-viewer involvement positively impact the perceived persuasiveness, which lead to purchase intention and response intention. Mindfulness positively moderates the relationship between the perceived persuasiveness and response intention.
Guo et al., [1]	Customer engagement	Trust transfer theory	Trust in broadcasters	Trust in community members, trust in products, swift guanixi	422 customers who have watched Taobao Live	Survey	Trust in community members, trust in products, trust in broadcasters has positive relationship with customer engagement and swift guanxi.
Li et al., [2]	Number of free gifts given in live commerce, number of paid gifts given	Identity-based motivation model	Class identity, relational identity	NA	193,439 observations	Econometric model	Class identity and relational identity positively relate to the number of paid gifts given and the number of free gifts given. An interaction effect exists between relational and class identities on the number of paid gifts given and the number of free gifts given.
Chen et al., [16]	Purchase intention in live commerce, willingness to pay more	Elaboration likelihood model, trust transfer theory	Perceived product quality, brand awareness, *perceived product knowledge of streamers*, other viewers' endorsement, value similarity	Trust in product, trust in streamer	545 livestreaming commerce users in China	Survey	Perceived product quality, perceived product knowledge, other members' endorsement, and value similarity relate positively to consumer's trust in product and trust in

(*continued on next page*)

Table 2 (*continued*)

Study	Research phenomena	Theory	Antecedents	Psychological mechanism	Sample	Method	Findings
							the streamers, which further lead to purchase intention.
Guo et al., [26]	Watching intention in live commerce, purchase intention	NA	*Beauty, expertise, humor, passion, warmth, popularity*	Utilitarian value, hedonic value	245 participants with the experience of watching live streaming	Survey	Streamer's beauty, warmth, expertise, humor, passion positively relate to perceived hedonic value and utilitarian value, which lead to watching intention and purchase intention.
He et al., [25]	Purchase intention in live commerce, consumer engagement	Two-factor theory, SOR theory	Motivation factors (*streamer physical attractiveness, interaction friendliness, altruism, expertise*; product price attractiveness, local uniqueness); hygiene factors (*streamer trustworthiness*, product authenticity, government credibility)	Hedonic benefit perception, utilitarian benefit perception, risk perception	687 participants with officer live streaming watching experience	Survey	Government credibility, officer streamer physical attractiveness, interaction friendliness, altruism, trustworthiness, product authenticity, product price attractiveness, product local uniqueness positively influences utilitarian and hedonic benefit perception and negatively influences risk perception, which lead to purchase intention and consumer engagement.
Ma et al., [17]	Purchase hesitation	The theory of telepresence	Consumer-anchor interaction, consumer-consumer interaction	Social presence, physical presence, trust	293 participants with live shopping experience	Survey	The interaction among consumers, between consumers and anchors has a positive impact on consumers' social presence and consumers' physical presence, which lead to consumer's trust.
Tong et al., [59]	Purchase intention	SOR theory	Background visual complexity	Pleasure, arousal	432 participants with live shopping experience	Experiment	Background visual complexity of live streaming has an inverted U-shaped effect on consumer pleasure, consumer arousal, and consumer purchase intention. Consumers' gender moderates the effect of live background visual complexity on their pleasure.
Wang et al., [39]	Purchase intention	Vividness theory	Retailing mode (livestreaming vs traditional)	Mental imagery quality, customer trust	162 consumers who had online purchase experiences	Experiment	Retailing mode and product type will interactively impact mental imagery quality, customer trust, and purchase intentions. The interaction effect of retailing mode and product type on purchase intention will be serially mediated by mental imagery quality and customer trust.
Zhang et al., [19]	Continuance intention	Social-technical systems theory, affordance theory	Social enabler-interactivity (active control, synchronicity); technical enabler-technology (two-way communication, *personalization*, visibility)	Trust in product, trust in streamer	446 Taobao live streaming users	Survey	Active control, synchronicity, two-way communication, personalization, visibility positively influences trust in streamers and trust in products, which lead to continuance intention. The effect of trust in streamers on continuance intention is stronger for customers who watch the live streaming of multi-brand streamers while the effect of trust in products on continuance intention is stronger for customers who

(*continued on next page*)

Table 2 (*continued*)

Study	Research phenomena	Theory	Antecedents	Psychological mechanism	Sample	Method	Findings
							watch the live streaming of fixed brand streamers.
Guan et al., [21]	Purchase intention of virtual gifts	Flow theory	IT-related factors (*responsiveness*, two-way communication, social presence, self-presentation), cultural characteristic (social orientation, harmony)	Perceived proximity to the streamer, flow (immersion, enjoyment, time distortion, perceived control), sense of belonging to the viewer crowd	461 live streaming viewers	Survey	Perceived proximity, sense of belonging, responsiveness, social presence, self-presentation, social orientation, harmony positively associate with flow, perceived proximity, sense of belonging and purchase of virtual gifts.
Liu et al., [9]	Continuous watching intention in live commerce, purchase intention	Information foraging theory	*Attractiveness*, perceived product fit, vividness, mutuality, price value	Perceived enjoyment, perceived serendipity, perceived diagnosticity	486 Chinese live shopping consumers	Survey, fsQCA	Broadcasters' attractiveness, perceived product fit, products' price value broadcasters' vividness, co-viewers' mutuality are positively related to perceived enjoyment, perceived serendipity, and perceived diagnosticity, which lead to continuous watching intention and purchase intention.
Xiong et al., [18]	Purchase intention	Affordance theory	Guidance shopping, triggered attending, social interaction	Trust, presence	266 participants who have used e-commerce live-streaming	Survey	Guidance shopping, triggered attending, and social interaction positively influence the consumers' trust in streamers and presence, which lead to purchase intention. Guidance shopping exerts a greater impact on males' trust in streamers than females' while triggered attending exerts a greater impact on females' trust in streamers than males'.
Zheng et al., [20]	Continuous watching intention in live commerce, purchase intention	Flow theory	Social presence, interactivity, *attractiveness, expertise*	Flow	367 Chinese live shopping consumers	Survey	Social presence, Interactivity positively influences flow, which lead to viewers' continuous watching intention and viewers' purchase intention. Optimal stimulation level positively moderates the effect of interactivity on flow.

Note: antecedent factors relating to influencer impressions are italicized.

more attention to amounts of efforts and detailed processes when striving toward goals, while men are more willing to devote energies to overcoming obstacles and constraints in accomplishing objectives [38, 87].

Although empirical evidence has shown the equality across biological sexes of women and men in computer literacy and technology use in general, gender stereotypes persist in the digital age [88,89]. Scholars have uncovered gender differences concerning information processing, motivation, and behavioral tendencies in various e-commerce contexts, such as group buying [90], e-learning [39], and online auctions [91]. When processing information available from online stores, female consumers pay more attention to emotional cues while male ones value functional information more [68,92]. Hwang and Lee [93] use an eye-tracking method and obtain similar findings that during online shopping female and male consumers are sensitive to atmospheric and product information, respectively. In addition, female consumers' purchase decisions are more likely driven by hedonic motivation such as sociality, whereas male ones' attention centers upon utilitarian motivation such as cost saving and convenience [94]. As such, gender is a critical factor to be considered in our investigative context of live commerce.

3. Research model and hypotheses

Following the S-O-R framework and social role theory, we build our research model and propose nine hypotheses (see Fig. 1). We first explain the differential influences of the three influencers' impression management tactics as Stimulus (S) on the two types of trust as Organism (O). We then hypothesize the transfer process from trust in influencers to trust in products, together with their respective impacts on purchase intention as Response (R). Finally, we portray gender differences regarding the relationship strength between trust and purchase intention.

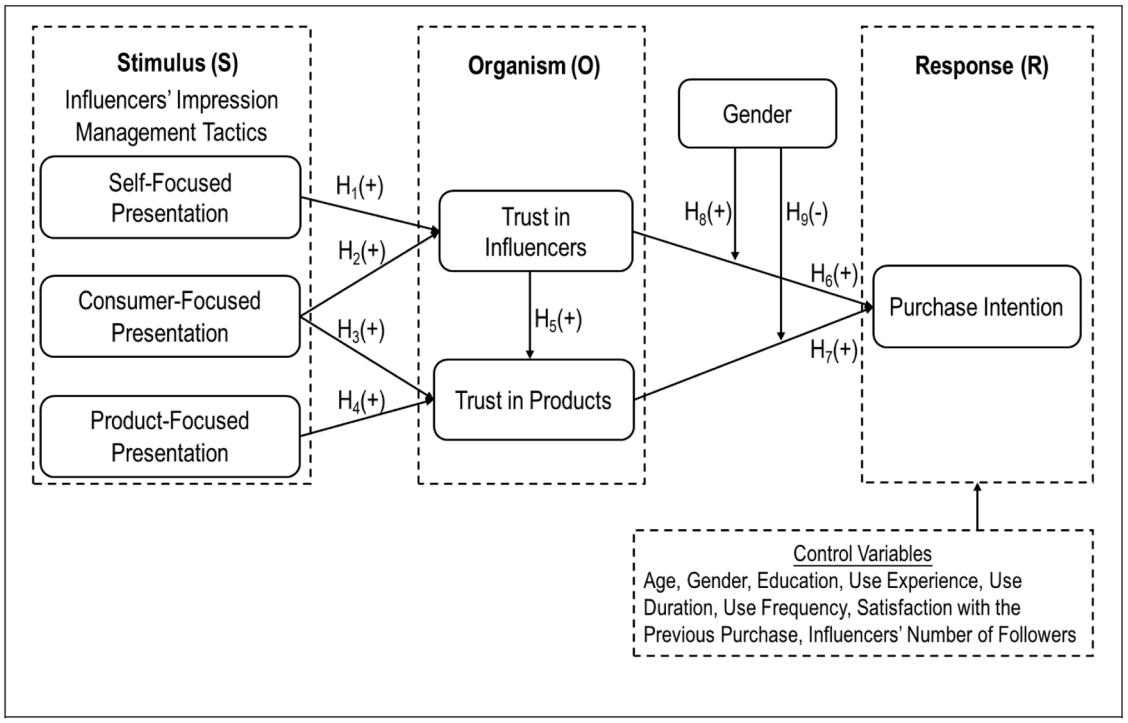


Fig. 1. Research model of purchase intention in live commerce.

3.1. Impression management tactics and trust perceptions

With a self-focused presentation tactic, sellers share their professional experiences and demonstrate competent capabilities to audiences, making themselves attractive to potential buyers [57]. In live commerce, influencers also create desired images in terms of trustworthiness through self-focused presentation [95]. For instance, Li Jiaqi, one of the most popular influencers of beauty products, successfully challenged the Guinness World Record for applying lipstick to clients within 30 s. Such public shows in live channels help influencers build a reputation among audiences; audiences in turn believe in influencers' knowledge in offering high-quality recommendations and products. A professional English teacher also engaged in a fascinating English-speaking talk show when selling English textbooks through live commerce. As such, potential buyers trust that the influencer's expertise in language teaching allows him to provide valuable suggestions and reference books for learning English [12,96].

Indeed, the self-focused presentation tactics let influencers present their skills and knowledge, alleviating buyers' suspicion of possible information asymmetry and opportunistic behaviors in online business transactions [97]. Convinced by influencers' knowledge and expertise in their sales-related domain, consumers would perceive their recommendations of purchasing related products as useful and valuable [16]. Meanwhile, presentations encompassing personal stories or usage experiences potentially arouse effective resonance among viewers. By doing so, influencers foster an emotional bond with potential consumers that transcends beyond traditional commercial transactions [161]. As such, consumers would be persuaded to buy any products that fall in the professional domain of influencers since they believe the deals recommended by experts are good ones. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1 Influencers' self-focused presentation has a positive effect on buyers' trust in influencers.

Consumer-focused presentation refers to influencers' statements and behaviors that are oriented toward consumers' needs and interests [55]. Influencers with a consumer-focused presentation tactic interact with potential buyers with a humble and affiliative tone, showing their benevolence toward consumers [21]. Consumers who are exposed to consumer-focused presentation tend to experience a high level of social presence and be willing to maintain strong social ties with influencers [8]. Consequently, the consumer-focused presentation makes consumers feel that they are receiving attention and recognition from influencers, which shortens their psychological distance from influencers and nurtures the perceptions that influencers are like approachable friends [96,98]. Furthermore, the consumer-focused presentation also includes offering tailored product recommendations, showing influencers' capability and reliability in responding to specific consumer needs and preferences. For example, influencers often encourage audiences to raise questions or share personal experiences through all kinds of live functions, such as voice connections and bullet messages, and then provide prompts and individualized responses [13,99]. As such, consumers would be motivated to seek any product information from the likable sellers, and their risk perceptions in business transactions are in turn mitigated [100,101]. Hence, we theorize the following:

Hypothesis 2 Influencers' consumer-focused presentation has a positive effect on buyers' trust in influencers.

Influencers' consumer-focused presentation tactics also enhance consumers' trust in products for two reasons. First, when influencers' statements and presentations are oriented toward consumers' queries, needs, and interests, they present information in a way that is tailored to consumers' personalized contexts or scenarios. As such, consumers tend to feel that influencers have a good understanding of their needs and how products fit their needs, which mitigates uncertainty perceptions and facilitates their judgment [14,15]. Second, influencers' consumer-focused presentation also makes consumers feel being valued and consequently satisfied with pre-sales services [13,19]. Since service quality is closely tied to product quality, satisfied online consumers also trust the expected performance of products in live commerce [102,103]. Therefore, we propose:

Hypothesis 3 Influencers' consumer-focused presentation has a positive effect on buyers' trust in products.

Product-focused presentation stands for influencers' demonstrating product functions comprehensively and attractively [55,58]. While it is usually difficult for consumers to verify product quality via online texts

and images, influencers in live commerce can act as a live "shopping guide" and instantly display products in various ways to audiences [104,105]. In other words, faced with ambiguity and uncertainty in the online shopping context, consumers always rely on influencers' live shows for diagnosis and judgment [95]. Hung et al. [13] further suggest that product-focused presentations and live shows are in line with consumers' pragmatic mindset and can fulfill their instrumental shopping needs. Influencers, through all-round demonstration of products in live shows, effectively convey product knowledge and help consumers to understand products in terms of quality, performance, and functions. As such, product-focused presentation not only reduces information asymmetry but also satisfies consumers' needs for product diagnosis and detailed evaluation [12]. Consequently, consumers' concerns about products' uncertain performances will be reduced [99,106] and their trust in products eventually be boosted [158]. As a result, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 4 Influencers' product-focused presentation has a positive effect on buyers' trust in products.

3.2. Trust transfer and purchase intention

According to trust transfer theory, trust in one person can be transferred to related persons or entities [74,75]. Following this logic, we predict that trust can be transferred from influencers to their products in live commerce for the following reasons. For one, when consumers believe in influencers' professional knowledge, they will sense a high level of diagnosticity in product description and demonstration offered by the influencers and thus make positive judgments on product function and performance based on live shows [19]. For another, from a relational perspective, when consumers perceive influencers to be trustworthy, they become willing to follow their live accounts and develop social bonds with them [1]. Such a buyer-seller social tie brings halo effects and fosters illusionary feelings that product performance will be consistent with the product information provided by influencers [35]. Accordingly, trust in products can be generated via trust in influencers, and we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 5 Buyers' trust in influencers has a positive effect on their trust in products.

Purchase intention refers to the willingness of consumers to purchase products from a seller [107]. Consumers can only view products at a distance instead of face-to-face in online shopping and this tends to feel risky and consumers become hesitant to make a purchase decision. Trust—the willingness to be vulnerable to the other party or entity—is an essential psychological state that helps consumers reduce uncertainty perceptions [108] and motivate their purchase behaviors in online shopping [103]. We believe that both trust perceptions in influencers and in products nurture consumers' purchase intention in live commerce.

First, trust in influencers characterizes a buyer-seller relationship in which consumers believe that influencers will consider their interests and thus are reliable [30]. When trust is established in the buyer-seller relationship, consumers are confident that influencers will keep their promises and their future behaviors are predictable [19]. As such, trust in influencers rules out uncertainty barriers between influencers and consumers, and consumers become willing to purchase products from the influencers [35]. Moreover, trustworthy perceptions also cultivate consumers' positive attitudes toward product quality and credibility, which motivate their purchase intention [6]. Accordingly, we propose:

Hypothesis 6 Buyers' trust in influencers has a positive effect on purchase intention.

Second, trust in products, consumers' perceptions that products will display standard performance that is per influencers' descriptions, also carries paramount importance in live commerce transactions [19]. A high level of trust in products makes consumers sensitive to the benefit information of products rather than the information relating to risks or costs [35]. In other words, when consumers trust in product quality, they are less likely to spend extra time and energy searching and comparing similar products but can quickly arrive at purchase decisions. On the opposite side, when consumers lack trust in products, they often question the authenticity of product information and performance and stay hesitant during purchase processes [17]. As such, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 7 Buyers' trust in products has a positive effect on purchase intention.

3.3. The moderating role of gender

Previous studies have found that women and men behave differently when shopping online. Per the social role theory, gender-specific patterns also manifest in economic decision-making scenarios, wherein women typically prioritize their relationships with significant others, while men tend to logical reasoning and the pursuit of instrumental needs [109]. Specifically, women engage in e-commerce activities mainly because of social interactions, while men shop online for task-related purposes [68,110]. Therefore, we expect that the relationships between trust perceptions and purchase intentions in live commerce are also contingent upon gender.

On the one hand, relative to their male counterparts, female consumers exhibit a heightened sensitivity to social interactions [111,162]. Specifically, the decision-making process of female consumers is predominantly influenced by their emotional and cognitive responses to the sellers with whom they engage [18]. In this vein, females tend to be more relationship-oriented than males, and value influencers together with real-time social activities with them to a greater extent in live commerce. Given a similar level of trust in influencers, female consumers tend to derive more interest as well as satisfaction through interacting with influencers than their male peers. As such, females' purchase intentions and decisions are more likely to be driven by trust in influencers than males [112].

In contrast, male consumers demonstrate a proclivity for perceiving live commerce shopping as a goal-oriented activity, directing their focus towards product-related cues during the decision-making process [111,113]. In comparison to their female counterparts, males tend to invest greater efforts in evaluating products, emphasizing aspects such as presentation accuracy and price fairness [38,110,114]. In face of a similar level of trust in products, male consumers tend to perceive a higher level of trustworthiness in products than female ones, which triggers their purchase intention. Consequently, male consumers are more likely to make purchase decisions when they believe in the function and quality of products than female ones [93]. Accordingly, we theorize:

Hypothesis 8 The effect of trust in influencers on purchase intention is stronger for females than for males.

Hypothesis 9 The effect of trust in products on purchase intention is stronger for males than for females.

4. Method

Since influencers' impression management behaviors in the live commerce context is an emerging phenomenon and has seldom been characterized by the extant literature, we adopt a mixed-method approach and triangulate both qualitative and quantitative data to examine how the influencers' impression management tactics affect consumers' purchase intentions [164]. The mixed-method research design is a practical tool for obtaining comprehensive insights into the emerging but complex phenomenon [115,163,116]. In our research, we first conduct a qualitative investigation of semi-structured interviews with live commerce consumers to (1) gain first-hand insights about the influencers' impression management behaviors in the view of consumers, (2) confirm the classification validity of influencers' three impression management tactics in live commerce context; and (3) better design measurement scales of the three impression management tactics in the qualitative study. We then empirically tested the proposed

research hypotheses in the quantitative study.

4.1. Study 1

4.1.1. Procedures and participants

The semi-structured interviews in Study 1 aim to obtain qualitative insights about how consumers understand influencers' impression management behaviors in the live commerce context. As such, Study 1 not only helps confirm the dimensionality of influencers' impression management tactics proposed in our research model, but also offers primary insights on the measurement scales of these constructs in Study 2. We recruited 87 college students in an introductory information systems course from one of largest universities in northern China to participate in our semi-structured interviews. We retained 71 participants who had rich live commerce shopping experiences, comprised of 35 females and 36 males and aged between 18 and 24 years old. Such student sample from a single university a) represents a key segment of the live commerce consumer population [117], b) is suitable for live commerce research [165,166], and c) can help enhance internal validity through reducing external noise and potential bias ([96,166].

We interviewed the 71 participants one by one following the semi-structured interview guide in Appendix A. At the beginning of each interview session, we introduced the investigative context of live commerce as well as our research objective. We promised that the interview content would be kept confidential but recorded and transcribed, and asked for the informed consent from the interviewees. We then invited the interviewees to recall the details of their most recent shopping experience in live commerce and asked them to describe in detail regarding how influencers behave in the live commerce settings, for example, content, appearance, gestures, tones, facial expressions, and responses to consumers. Based on their sharing, we followed up with a few extended questions relating to influencers' specific impression management tactics. We also asked for interviewees' age and gender, as well as their live commerce shopping frequency and experiences, then compensated them RMB 30 for participation in the end. Each interview session lasted for about 20 min.

The interview content on influencers' different impression management tactics in live commerce saturated with about the first 25 interviewees [118,119]. However, we observed that most of the purchased products shared by the interviewees were different from one another, though most of them belong to the experience product category. Hence, we decided to complete the interviews for each of the 71 participants. Two postgraduate students in the master program of information systems helped transcribe the interview records and ensure content accuracy. All interviews together with the transcription were completed within two weeks in early 2022.

4.1.2. Identification and categorization of impression management tactic

Since the semi-structured interviews aim to explore and confirm the dimensionality of influencers' impression management tactics in live commerce, we conduct a thematic analysis of the transcribed text data from the interviews ([163]; Kummer et al., 2021). We first formed a coding group consisting of two doctoral students and a professor in information systems and followed a three-stage procedure to conduct the qualitative analysis [168,169]. In the first stage, the two student coders independently conducted open coding with *NVivo 12.0*, a software for analyzing unstructured text data, to identify influencers' impression management actions and behaviors at the sentence level [120]. In particular, we asked the coders to possibly include any of the three key objects when performing open coding—influencer, viewer, and product, which are well rooted in the impression management literature and also constitute the live commerce setting. As such, the three objects serve as instrumental theoretical threads as well as useful reference cues throughout the coding and categorization processes in later stages.

In the second stage, the two student coders independently engaged in the axial coding stage, by iteratively comparing and consolidating influencers' impression management behaviors and actions that were conceptually similar into broader categories [168,121]). Finally, the two coders independently performed selective coding by synthesizing the sub-themes identified in the axial coding stage into higher-order themes. The Cohen's kappa value of the coding results from the two student coders was 0.85, well surpassing the reference value of 0.70 [167]. The professor then acted as an independent judge and organized a discussion with the two student coders to reconcile any inconsistencies in the coding results and finalize the coding schema [168,121]).

The coding results derived from the qualitative investigation are summarized in Table 3. Through the three steps of open coding, axial coding, and selective coding, we identified and also confirmed the existence of three impression management tactics, namely self-focused, consumer-focused, and product-focused presentation. Each theme further entails three sub-themes. Specifically, self-focused presentation has the sub-themes of appearance (31.0 %), professional accreditation (18.3 %), and facial expression and gestures (29.6 %). Consumer-focused presentation includes the sub-themes of being responsive to viewers' queries and questions (29.6 %), calling viewers using nicknames (38.0 %), and discussing common interests with viewers and complimenting viewers (16.9 %). Last, product-focused presentation contains three sub-themes of discounted price (32.4 %), functions and values (25.4 %), and quality (21.1 %).

It is important to note that the three impression management tactics are not necessarily categorical in nature. Being good at one impression management tactic, say, product-focused tactic, does not necessarily mean the influencer should be less effective in practicing the other two tactics. More often than not, influencers who are good at one presentation tactic also tend to be sophisticated at performing other tactics. In other words, one influencer can be mastery of more than one impression management tactic at the same time. Moreover, interviewees also confirmed that even if one influencer displays more than one impression management tactics during live shows, the levels of sophistication of these tactics might be different from one another. As such, we consider the three impression management tactics can be appropriately quantified through Likert-based measurement scales in Study 2.

We further examined the inference quality of our coding work from two aspects, design quality and explanation quality [122–124]. For one, we designed semi-structured interviews with an open question on interviewees' latest live commerce shopping experience, and then followed up with queries with specific regard to influencer, viewer, and product—the three core elements are well engrained in the impression management literature and also serve as the fundamentals that comprise live commerce transactions. Meanwhile, our college students sample represented the key market segment of live commerce, which offered plausible and adequate inputs to our investigation. For another, we integrated the taxonomy of influencer, viewer, and product, which are consistent with the impression management literature, when performing initial open coding. Also, we not only statistically examined the inconsistencies between the two coders' results, but also hired a senior professor to act as an independent judge and ensure the explanation quality of the text analysis results.

Given that we have confirmed that influencers' impression management tactics in the live commerce context entail three facets of self-focused, consumer-focused, and product-focused presentations, we follow this tri-dimensional conceptualization and used the qualitative inputs of Study 1 to develop the measurement scales of influencers' impression management tactics in Study 2 and test the research model with quantitative data.

4.2. Study 2

4.2.1. Procedures and participants

Study 2 involves a survey based on scenarios to quantitatively investigate how the three types of influencers' tactics for managing impressions impact viewers' trust perceptions and subsequently lead to

Table 3
Categorization of impression management tactics.

Themes	Sub-themes	Exemplary quotations	Times mentioned	Numbers of interviewees (Percent)
Self-focused presentation	Appearance	• "The influencer dressed up and wore some very eye-catching clothes." (R31)	27	22 (31.0 %)
	Professional accreditation	• "The influencer showed some professional certifications about him/herself, highlighting his/her expertise in related products." (R43)	16	13 (18.3 %)
	Facial expressions and gestures	• "The influencer made some funny expressions and attractive gestures to attract viewers." (R63)	27	21 (29.6 %)
Consumer-focused presentation	Be responsive to viewers' queries and questions	• "The influencer responded to viewers' bullet messages in the first time and tried on the particular products as requested by viewers." (R5)	26	21 (29.6 %)
	Call viewers using nicknames	• The influencer called viewers using nicknames like "sweeties" or "babies" to shorten their distance with viewers." (R15)	34	27 (38.0 %)
	Discuss common interests with viewers or complement viewers	• "The influencer encouraged viewers to discuss the topics that they would be interested in and complimented their active involvement such as sending "likes" and virtual gifts." (R16)	14	12 (16.9 %)
Product-focused presentation	Discounted product price	• "The influencer disclosed the discounts or special offers in an attractive way during live streaming, highlighting the affordability of the product." (R70)	27	23 (32.4 %)
	Product functions and values	• "The influencer diligently explained product values and demonstrated the important and unique product functions." (R61)	19	18 (25.4 %)
	Product quality	• "The influencer performed on-site testing of product features, proofing that the product was of high quality." (R8)	20	15 (21.1 %)

Note: R means interviewee; all interviewees were coded from R1 to R71.

purchases in live commerce. We chose Douyin (TikTok) as the target live commerce platform for the following reasons. First, Douyin is a highly popular live streaming platform and its users spent on average at least 89 min per day on the mobile application [125]. Second, Douyin launched the live commerce business since December 2018. The transaction volume of Douyin live commerce surpassed RMB 381.2 billion by the end of 2020; more than two thirds of the online customers in China have learnt Douyin live commerce [126]. Third, the number of influencers on Douyin has grown rapidly over the past three years and exceeded 3 million by June 2022 (Cicada [127]). Industry reports show that the sales revenue of Douyin influencers accounted for about 50 % of the Gross Merchandise Volume of the platform, engendering an "influencer economy" (Cicada [13,128]).

The scenario-based survey targets Douyin users who had live commerce purchase experience via the platform in the past six months. At the start of the survey, we set a screening question, "Have you purchased any products from Douyin live commerce in the past six months?" We only retained the participants who answered "yes" to this question. Next, we obtained the informed consent from the participants, and asked their demographic information (i.e., age, gender, and education) and usage information of Douyin (i.e., years of use experience, use duration per day, use frequency per week). In the main section of the survey, we invited the participants to recall their latest purchase experience on Douyin live commerce. The participants needed to write down the detailed information about the influencer's name and the approximate range of their follower numbers, as well as the purchased product name, so that they better recollected relevant information about the purchase experience. We then asked about their feelings toward the influencer's different impression management tactics, their trust perceptions, their satisfaction with the purchase experience, and their purchase intention with the same influencer. All participants were compensated with RMB 5 in the end.

A consulting firm helped with our data collection process. The consulting firm randomly picked 25 live rooms of different influencers on Douyin and sent the weblink of the online survey as live bullet chats (i.e., *danmu*) at random times in the third week of March 2022. We were able to collect data from 255 participants and retained 241 valid responses as the final sample, which satisfies the sample requirement that 10 times the number of items in the construct with the most measures [129]. We deleted those with straight-line answers or completion time less than 1.5 min. Table 4 shows the demographic information and Douyin usage information of our sample. Specifically, Douyin users who were female, younger than age 30 years, and with daily use duration over 30 min accounted for the majority of our sample population, which is consistent with the recent Douyin e-commerce report (Douyin [130,131]).

Table 4
Sample demographics.

Characteristics	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Age	<18	2	0.8
	18–23	158	65.6
	24–30	64	26.6
	30–42	13	5.4
	>42	4	1.7
Gender	Male	81	33.6
	Female	160	66.4
Education	High school and below	8	3.3
	Associate or Bachelor's degree	189	78.5
	Master's degree and above	44	18.3
Douyin use experience	Less than 1 years	36	14.9
	1–2 years	79	32.8
	3–4 years	93	38.6
	More than 4 years	33	13.7
Douyin use duration per day	Less than 15 min	46	19.1
	15 min-30 min	41	17.0
	30 min-1 hr	54	22.4
	1–2 hrs	53	22.0
	More than 2 hrs	47	19.5
Douyin use frequency per week	0–1 days	36	14.9
	2–3 days	44	18.3
	4–5 days	24	10.0
	Almost every day	137	56.8
Influencers' number of followers	5 thousand – 10 thousand	34	14.1
	10 thousand – 100 thousand	55	22.8
	100 thousand – 500 thousand	46	19.1
	500 thousand – 1 million	34	14.1
	1 million – 5 million	39	16.2
	Over 5 million	33	13.7

We also employed two different approaches to examine the potential non-response bias with our data [132]. First, we statistically compared the demographic information (i.e., age, gender, and education) and the Douyin usage information (i.e., years of use experience, use duration, and use frequency) between the final sample of the 241 respondents and

the 14 deleted ones, and the t-test results were all insignificant. Second, we compared the mean values of the six key constructs in the research model (i.e., three forms of impression management tactics, two types of trust, and purchase intention) between the first and the last 20 % respondents according to the timeline of data collection. Again, the results of t-tests were all insignificant. Therefore, the nonresponse bias was not a major threat to our data.

4.2.2. Instrument development

The measures of three impression management tactics were developed by integrating both the qualitative inputs of Study 1 and the existing scales of impression management; the measures of other constructs were adapted from previous studies and slightly modified to fit the live commerce context (see Table B1 Appendix B). The items of self-focused presentation were from Liu et al. [133]; the items of consumer-focused presentation were adapted from De Dreu and Nauta [134], as well as Stevens and Kristof [57]; the items of product-focused presentation were also borrowed from Stevens and Kristof [57]. The measures of trust in influencers were slightly revised based on the measures by Liu et al. [133], and the ones for trust in products were adapted from Fang and Li [135]. The items of purchase intention were adopted from Filieri and Lin [136]. We also collected information regarding influencers' follower numbers and participants' satisfaction with the previous purchase [137] as important control variables for purchase intention. In addition, we controlled for age, gender, education, and Douyin use information in terms of use experience in years, use duration per day, use frequency per week. We used a 7-point Likert scale for all self-reported measures, ranging from 1 as strongly disagree to 7 as strongly agree.

We used the back-translation technique to convert the English version questionnaire into Chinese [138]. We first invited an IS researcher to translate the English questionnaire into Chinese. Then, the Chinese version questionnaire was translated back into English by another IS researcher. A third IS researcher compared the translated English version with the original English version and made minor changes to the Chinese version so as to ensure there was no semantic discrepancies in the Chinese version. After that, we conducted a pilot study with 43 college students and further refined the Chinese questionnaire according to the feedback from the polit sample.

5. Data analysis and findings

5.1. Measurement model

The measurement model of the six key constructs in the research model displayed good fit indices (chi-square/d.f. = 2.139, CFI = 0.949, SRMR = 0.067, and RMSEA = 0.069) [139,140]. In addition, we examined the reliability and convergent validity of each construct. As shown in Table 5, each construct's Cronbach's alpha (from 0.845 to 0.934) and composite reliability (from 0.889 to 0.957) exceeded the recommended value of 0.7 [141], thereby demonstrating good reliability for each construct. The values of average variance extracted (AVE) (from 0.669 to 0.880) were higher than the threshold value of 0.50 [142], supporting the convergent validity of each construct.

We also observed satisfactory discriminant validity among the six constructs according to two different criteria. For one, the square roots of AVE of each construct were larger than their correlations with other constructs (see Table 5) [141]. For another, the Heterotrait–Monotrait (HTMT) values were lower than the reference value of 0.85 (see Table 6) [143]. Finally, multicollinearity with our data was ruled out because the variance inflation factor values (from 1.042 to 2.416) were lower than the benchmark of 3.3 [144].

The potential for common method bias to inflate collected data is a significant concern. To address this issue, we implemented both procedural and statistical remedies to solve the common method bias [145]. For the procedural remedy, we guaranteed the anonymity of participants and ensured the confidentiality of the data throughout the data collection process. Additionally, we randomized the order of measurement items in the questionnaire, thereby minimizing the likelihood of respondents detecting any relationships between concept scales. As for the statistical approach, we initially performed a Harman's single-factor test, followed by a marker-variable test. For the marker-variable test, we selected resentment, a construct encompassing jealousy and hatred towards others [146], as our marker variable to perform the marker-variable test with Amos 23.0. [147,148]. The results showed that common method bias was not a major concern with our data (see Appendix C).

Table 5
Psychometric properties, means, standard deviations, and correlations.

	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. SFP	*0.889*					
2. CFP	0.367**	*0.818*				
3. PFP	0.600**	0.390**	*0.893*			
4. TRI	0.478**	0.459**	0.475**	*0.890*		
5. TRP	0.351**	0.512**	0.511**	0.678**	*0.908*	
6. PI	0.339**	0.548**	0.437**	0.656**	0.724**	*0.938*
Mean	5.681	4.721	5.423	4.767	4.689	4.804
Standard Deviation	1.225	1.224	1.239	1.334	1.177	1.237
Cronbach's Alpha	0.934	0.845	0.917	0.912	0.929	0.932
Composite Reliability	0.950	0.889	0.940	0.939	0.949	0.957
Average Variance Extracted (AVE)	0.790	0.669	0.797	0.793	0.824	0.880

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention. $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, two-tailed test.

Table 6
Heterotrait-monotrait ratios (HTMT).

	1	2	3	4	5
1. SFP					
2. CFP	0.411				
3. PFP	0.652	0.413			
4. TRI	0.511	0.466	0.496		
5. TRP	0.377	0.540	0.545	0.735	
6. PI	0.360	0.582	0.456	0.712	0.776

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention.

5.2. Structural model and hypotheses tests

We employed Mplus 8.3, the most popular covariance-based structural equation modeling analytical software, to test the structural model and research hypotheses. Model 1 examines the direct effects of three impression management tactics on two types of trust, and of trust perceptions on purchase intention, and Model 2 examines the moderation effects of gender on the relationships between trust and purchase intention, both of which exhibited good model fit (Model 1: chi-square/d.f. = 2.085, CFI = 0.920, SRMR = 0.064, RMSEA = 0.067; Model 2: chi-square/d.f. = 2.097, CFI = 0.914, SRMR = 0.062, RMSEA = 0.068) [139,140]. In Model 1 of Table 7, self-focused presentation (β = 0.386**, $p < 0.01$) and consumer-focused presentation ($\beta = 0.289^{**}$, $p <$ 0.01) had positive influences on trust in influencer, supporting H1 and H2. Meanwhile, consumer-focused presentation ($\beta = 0.232^{**}$, $p < 0.01$) and product-focused presentation (β = 0.196*, $p < 0.05$) had positive impacts on trust in product, supporting H3 and H4. In addition, trust in influencers had both positive influences on trust in products (β =

Table 7
Structural model results.

		Model 1 Direct model			Model 2 Moderation model		
		TRI	TRP	PI	TRI	TRP	PI
Self-focused presentation (SFP)		0.386** (0.000)		-0.046 (0.532)	0.387** (0.000)		-0.095 (0.186)
Consumer-focused presentation (CFP)		0.289** (0.005)	0.232** (0.008)	0.229* (0.020)	0.287** (0.005)	0.230** (0.008)	0.192* (0.033)
Product-focused presentation (PFP)			0.196* (0.046)	-0.029 (0.706)		0.202* (0.045)	-0.012 (0.868)
Trust in influencers (TRI)			0.527** (0.000)	0.269** (0.008)		0.525** (0.000)	0.329** (0.001)
Trust in products (TRP)				0.493** (0.000)			0.478** (0.000)
Gender				-0.044 (0.296)			-0.034 (0.415)
Control variables	Age			0.006 (0.881)			-0.022 (0.512)
	Education			0.012 (0.777)			0.027 (0.537)
	Use experience			0.016 (0.722)			0.022 (0.635)
	Use duration			0.019 (0.780)			0.001 (0.989)
	Use frequency			0.045 (0.485)			0.056 (0.386)
	Satisfaction with the previous purchase			0.055 (0.186)			0.056 (0.188)
	Influencers' number of followers			0.010 (0.829)			-0.002 (0.960)
Interactions	Gender*TRI						0.199** (0.006)
	Gender*TRP						-0.179* (0.021)
R^2		32.1 %	58.7 %	68.0 %	32.0 %	58.7 %	69.4 %

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention. $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, two-tailed test. Standardized path coefficients with p-values in parentheses.

0.527**, $p < 0.01$) and purchase intention ($\beta = 0.269^{*}$, $p < 0.05$). Therefore, both H5 and H6 were supported. Trust in products also positively impacted purchase intention ($\beta = 0.493^{**}$, $p < 0.01$), supporting H7.

In Model 2 of Table 7, gender positively moderated ($\beta = 0.199^{**}$, $p < 0.01$) the effect of trust in influencers on purchase intention, but negatively moderated ($\beta = -0.179^{*}$, $p < 0.05$) the effect of trust in products on purchase intention. Thus, H8 and H9 were both supported. We depicted the interaction diagrams in Fig. 2. Specifically, trust in influencers had a positive influence on purchase intention for both females ($\beta_{female} = 0.535^{**}$, $p < 0.01$) and males ($\beta_{male} = 0.182$, $p > 0.05$), and this impact was stronger for female than for male sample. Trust in products positively impacted purchase intention for both females ($\beta_{female} = 0.334^{**}$, $p < 0.01$) and males ($\beta_{male} = 0.651^{**}$, $p < 0.01$), and this impact was stronger for male than for female sample.

5.3. Post-hoc analysis

We performed post-hoc analysis and further obtained nuanced understanding of our theoretical model. First, we conducted mediation tests with our research model using Mplus 8.0. We used 1000 bootstrap resamples to estimate confidence intervals (CI) of the six mediation effects [170]. The results in Table 8 show that trust in influencers mediated the positive effects of self-focused presentation (β = 0.104, 95 % CI: [0.035, 0.214]) and consumer-focused presentation (β = 0.078, 95 % CI: [0.020, 0.166]) on purchase intention. Trust in products mediated the

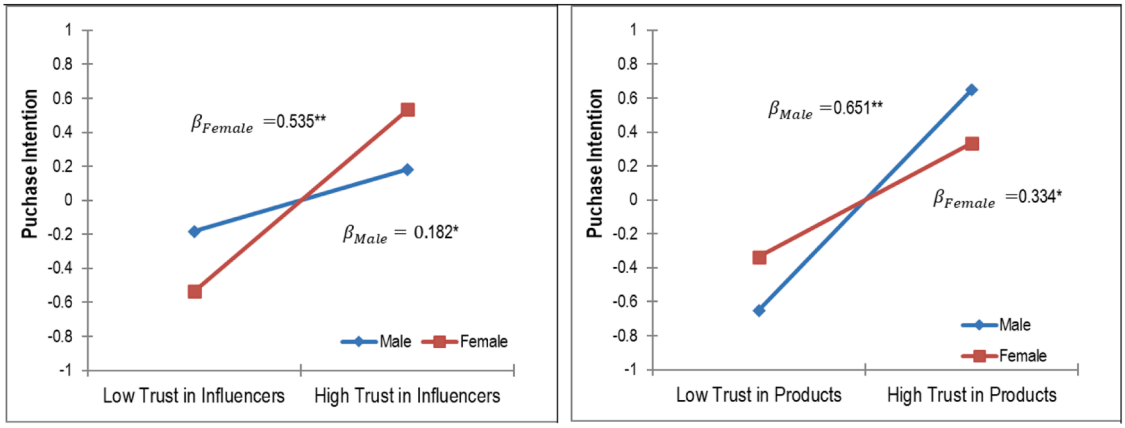


Fig. 2. a. Interaction diagram (H8). **2b.** Interaction diagram (H9)
Notes: $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, two-tailed test. Unstandardized path coefficients.

Table 8
Mediation test results.

Mediation path	Indirect effects	Bias-corrected 95 % Confidence intervals (CIs)	
SFP→TRI→PI	0.104	0.035	0.214
SFP→TRI→TRP→PI	0.100	0.044	0.183
CFP→TRI→PI	0.078	0.020	0.166
CFP→TRI→TRP→PI	0.075	0.023	0.160
CFP→TRP→PI	0.114	0.014	0.247
PFP→TRP→PI	0.097	0.032	0.212

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention.

positive effects of product-focused presentation (β = 0.097, 95 % CI: [0.032, 0.212]) and consumer-focused presentation (β = 0.114, 95 % CI: [0.014, 0.247]) on purchase intention. In addition, the indirect paths between self-focused presentation and purchase intention through trust in influencers and trust in products were significant (β = 0.100, 95 % CI: [0.044, 0.183]); the indirect paths between consumer-focused presentation and purchase intention through trust in influencers and trust in products were also significant (β = 0.075, 95 % CI: [0.023, 0.160]). Therefore, we conclude that trust in influencer and trust in products appropriately transferred the influencers' impression management stimulus into viewers' purchase behaviors.

In addition, we added two causal relationships in the original research model, that is, from self-focused presentation to trust in products, and from product-focused presentation to trust in influencers. We replicated the hypotheses tests procedures in Mplus 8.0. We summarized all detailed results of the structural models and mediation tests in Appendix D, all of which remain qualitatively unchanged (see Tables D1 and D2). Interestingly, we find that self-focused presentation was negatively related to trust in products (β = -0.198*, $p < 0.05$). This indicates that influencers' too much focus on presenting themselves tend to hurt viewers' trust in products, since viewers may suspect that the influencers' over demonstration of their versatile images aim to cover up the defects of their products [149]. In addition, we observed a non-significant relationship between product-focused presentation and trust in influencers (β = 0.149, $p > 0.05$). This supports our original research model construction in which we did not hypothesize such an association, as too much presentation of products only causes adverse effects among viewers, such as information overload and visual fatigue, and does not necessarily relate to their perceptions of influencers [150].

6. Discussion

Our study draws on the impression management lens and integrates both the S-O-R framework and social role theory to understand how the influencers' impression management tactics foster future purchase intentions. With semi-structured interviews with 71 college students, we identified influencers' three forms of impression management tactics that are in accordance with the impression management literature in the management domain. With a scenario-based survey from 241 experienced live commerce buyers, we find that self- and consumer-focused presentation tactics build trust in influencers, while consumer- and product-focused presentation tactics nurture trust in products. In addition, trust in influencers elevates trust in products, both contributing to purchase intention. Finally, the path from trust in influencers to purchase intention only works for females, while the influence of trust in products on purchase intention is more pronounced for males than for females. In the following, we discuss the implications of our findings for theory development, future research, as well as practice.

6.1. Theoretical implications

Our theoretical model together with empirical findings offer the following contributions. First, our study is among the earliest attempts to apply the theoretical lens of impression management into the context of live commerce, which offers theoretical extension with regard to both impression management and live commerce literature. Specifically, we denote self-focused presentation as influencers' statements and behaviors that show themselves favorably and competently [57], consumer-focused presentation as influencers' statements and behaviors centering upon consumers and being responsive to consumers' needs or interests [55], and product-focused presentation as influencers' introducing product information in a comprehensive and appealing manner [58].

For one, the impression management lens is well-known in understanding many organizational behaviors [160], consumer behaviors [47], as well as technology use behaviors [49]. The essential difference between live commerce and other social commerce settings is that the interactive live streaming features allow influencers to create a particular online persona and present all aspects of themselves to attract followers and convert such online visits into commercial sales [2]. As such, the extension and contextualization of the impression management lens into the live commerce setting is worthwhile and potentially offers a new avenue for the theoretical development of social commerce in general and live commerce in particular.

For another, the extant live commerce studies have touched upon a few but not exhaustive impression management tactics of influencers. For instance, scholars discover that influencers with characteristics such as expertise [158], attractiveness [10], and humor [26] more easily persuade consumers and achieve more online sales. Others note that influencers' rapid and efficient responses to consumers using live features also enhance consumers' trust in their reliability [17,19]. Still, there is a significant gap regarding a comprehensive but systematic overview on what are the influencers' impression management tactics and how do such tactics affect viewers' purchase behaviors in live commerce. Our findings not only offer a comprehensive yet systematic overview of three impression management tactics in the live commerce context, but also confirm their empirical validity through both qualitative and quantitative studies. Moreover, our findings reveal that influencers' self-, consumer-, and product-focused presentation tactics promote consumers' purchase intentions by building up different types of trust, which is considered to be the second contribution below.

Second, this research offers an innovative angle of impression management regarding the trust-building processes in live commerce. We theoretically differentiate two types of trust perceptions in the live commerce context, namely, trust in influencers and trust in products, and hypothesize and verify their differential roles in transmitting the influences of three impression management tactics on consumers' purchase intention in live commerce. While little prior research has identified two distinct types of trust—trust in streamers and trust in products, our work goes beyond this by examining the boundary conditions between these two types of trust and consumer purchase decisions. By clarifying this boundary, we provide a nuanced understanding of how trust manifests in different stages of consumer decision processes and how it ultimately impacts purchase behavior. Notably, our research identifies a key gender difference in perceptions and influences of these two types of trust. These findings shed new light on the role of gender in shaping consumer trust in diverse social commerce settings. More importantly, our work prompts researchers to explore additional potential boundary conditions that may modulate the relationships between different concrete trust perceptions and purchase decisions.

We also extend the theoretical insights regarding gender differences into live commerce. Previous research usually refers to social role theory [151] and portrays that female and male consumers form trust in the e-commerce context through different pathways [68,152]. Specifically, females' trust perceptions are more driven by social motives and affective cues, but males are more rational and instrumental when making economic decisions. Our study extends this rationale into the live

commerce context and further identifies the differential paths of how females and males progress from trust perceptions to purchase decisions. As shown in the results, females are more likely to make purchases based on their trust in influencers, and males tend to patronize influencers' live stores due to trust in products. Therefore, our study enriches the knowledge on how to effectively nurture female and male consumers' purchase behaviors through appropriate impression management tactics and trust-building processes.

6.2. Practical implications

Our research also offers practical guidelines to influencers and managers regarding how different impression management tactics can increase consumers' purchases in live commerce. First, our results show that the three impression management tactics to varying extent are valued by consumers in developing their trust in live commerce. However, the majority of influencers in live channels consider themselves to be opinion leaders and spend most of their efforts presenting only themselves or their products. We advise influencers to better balance their presentation tactics and particularly pay attention to followers' interests and needs in their live-selling shows, that is, consumer-focused presentation tactic [8,12]. Consumers' trust perceptions can only be built up when the three impression management tactics are effectively triangulated by influencers.

Second, we find that trust in influencers is transferrable into trust in products in live commerce, both contributing to purchase or repurchase intentions. As such, we suggest that both influencers and managers of live commerce continue their attempts to enhance consumers' trust perceptions, especially trust perceptions in influencers. Specifically, influencers can better equip themselves with professional knowledge. For instance, influencers can partake in related training workshops or forge collaborations with experts to demonstrate professional understandings in related domain. In doing so, influencers deliver convincing sales recommendations in live shows. Influencers as well as managers can also boost trust perceptions by either encouraging satisfied consumers to share their usage experiences in live shows or establishing robust customer service protocols and carefully responding to post-sales services or complaints. All these tactics constitute pivotal parts of e-word-of-mouth [19,153].

Third, our results surface the importance of gender differences turning trust perceptions into purchase decisions in live commerce. Thus, influencers are suggested to tailor and balance their impression management or trust-building tactics when approaching female and male consumer groups. To cater to female consumers' social and emotional needs, influencers should prioritize social interactions during live shows. Influencers can foster a communal spirit and create a welcoming and warm atmosphere through engaging storytelling or testimonials. Conversely, to sustain male consumers' interest, influencers should present products in a comprehensive and detailed manner [34,93]. Influencers can emphasize technical explanations of product features and benefits, showcasing unique selling points and specifications. In doing so, influencers can effectively build trust in themselves as well as in products, thereby cultivating purchase behaviors among both female and male consumers in live commerce.

6.3. Limitation and future research

Although our research marches a significant step forward in understanding consumers' purchase decisions and behaviors in live commerce from the impression management perspective, still much effort can be made to further advance the knowledge base relating to live commerce. First, although influencers' impression management tactics, trust, and purchase intentions are appropriately assessed through consumers' self-reported survey data, alternative operationalization approaches can help reveal more valuable and nuanced insights. For example, further research can use text mining methods to operationalize the three different impression management tactics, capture purchase behaviors using substantial transactional data from live commerce platforms or adopt fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis (fsQCA) to analyze the complex causality between impression management tactics and purchase behaviors.

Second, we used student samples for the qualitative study. Although we have argued the feasibility of a student sample to conduct live commerce research and extended the population diversity in the quantitative study, we still encourage future research to replicate our research model with different population groups (e.g., people with different occupations, the elderly who are usually digital immigrants and use technologies in a way differ from digital natives).

Third, we consider influencers' number of followers only as a control variable in the research model. Future research can break down specific categories of influencers, such as mega-influencers, macro-influencers, micro-influencers, and nano-influencers [13] and see if consumers behave differently toward impression management tactics of different types of influencers. Also, researchers may consider alternative factors other than gender as important contingencies when understanding consumer behaviors in live commerce, for example, product type, consumer preferences, etc.

Finally, like several prior studies in e-commerce settings [30,154], we observe relatively high correlations between trust in products, together with trust in sellers, and purchase intentions. We retained these variables in the research model despite their high correlation values, since both trust in products and trust in sellers are theoretically significant in predicting purchase intentions and play pivotal mediation roles in channeling the impacts of influencers' impression management tactics [155,156]. Future research is needed to unpack the underlying complexities among these relationships, for example, to explore the sequential mediation effects of the two trust perceptions on consumer purchases.

7. Conclusion

We investigate how influencers' three different impression management tactics promote female and male consumers' purchase intentions in live commerce. Influencers' self- and consumers-focused presentation tactics enhance consumers' trust in influencers, and their consumer- and product-focused presentation tactics foster trust in products. More importantly, female consumers' purchase intentions are more likely to be driven by trust in influencers, while male ones' decisions are more affected by trust in products. Our study offers a new perspective of impression management in helping social platforms and influencers promote sales in live commerce.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Xixi Li: Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Conceptualization. **Qian Wang:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Data curation. **Xinlin Yao:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Methodology, Funding acquisition. **Xiangbin Yan:** Supervision, Resources. **Ruihao Li:** Writing – original draft, Visualization, Methodology.

Conflict of interest

The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest.

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Appendix A. Interview guide of Study 1

1. The open-ended question about influencers' impression management behaviors in general.

Please recall your latest shopping experience in live commerce and describe in detail regarding how the influencer behaved in the live commerce setting, for example, appearance, gestures, tones, facial expressions, responses to consumers, and product demonstration content.

2. Follow-up questions about influencers' impression management tactics.

Do you think this influencer was attempting to differentiate him/herself from other influencers? How?

Do you think this influencer responded to viewers in an effective way? Why?

Do you think this influencer demonstrated the product in an attractive manner? Why?

Appendix B. Measurement items of Study 2

Table B1
Measurement items.

Constructs	Item
Self-focused presentation ([133]; findings from Study 1)	SFP1*. The influencer tries to make a good impression on others when using Douyin, in terms of clothing, hair style, or tones. (see R31 in Table 3 of Study 1)
	SFP2*. The influencer tries to present his knowledge or expertise in a favorable way. (see R43 in Table 3 of Study 1)
	SFP3. Douyin helps the influencer to present his/her best side to others.
	SFP4. The influencer usually discloses him/herself using positive expressions or gestures.
	SFP5. Overall, the disclosures of the influencer about him/herself are more positive than negative on Douyin.
Consumer-focused presentation [134,57]; findings from Study 1)	CFP1. The influencer is concerned about the queries from and the interests of the consumers when using Douyin.
	CFP2*. The influencer compliments the consumers who interact with her/him (see R16 in Table 3 of Study 1).
	CFP3. The influencer discusses non-product-related topics with the consumers when using Douyin.
	CFP4*. The influencer discusses interests he/she shared in common with the consumers. (see R16 in Table 3 of Study 1)
Product-focused presentation [57]; findings from Study 1)	PFP1. The influencer demonstrates the features of his/her products when using Douyin.
	PFP2*. The influencer describes the values of his/her products in an attractive way. (see R61 in Table 3 of Study 1)
	PFP3*. The influencer gets the main points of his/her products across, for example, special offers, discounts, unique features, and price versus quality performance (see R8, R61, R70, in Table 3 of Study 1).
	PFP4*. The influencer highlights the quality of his/her products when using Douyin (see R8 in Table 3 of Study 1).
Trust in influencers [133]	TRI1. The influencer would be trustworthy.
	TRI2. The influencer would tell the truth and fulfill promises related to product recommendations.
	TRI3. The influencer is always honest with consumers.
	TRI4. I trust that the influencer will keep consumers' best interests in mind.
Trust in products [135]	TRP1. Product recommendations by the influencer are sincere.
	TRP2. Product recommendations by the influencer are honest.
	TRP3. The influencer does not make false product recommendations.
	TRP4. Product recommendations by the influencer are trustworthy.
Purchase intention [136]	PI1. I would consider buying other products recommended by the influencer.
	PI2. The likelihood I would purchase other products recommended by the influencer is high.
	PI3. My willingness to buy products recommended by the influencer again would be high.
Resentment [147,146]	Res1. At times I feel I get a raw deal out of life.
	Res2. When I look back on what's happened to me, I can't help feeling resentful.
	Res3. Other people always seem to get the breaks that I do not get.
Satisfaction with the previous purchase [137]	SAT1. The experience that I have had with the influencer on Douyin has been satisfactory.

* Items that were developed based on the findings from Study 1.

Appendix C. Common method bias analysis of Study 2

Considering that our data were collected through questionnaire, the analysis results may be influenced by common method variance. Thus, we chose two ways to assess the common method bias. First, we conducted Harman's single-factor test using SPSS 24.0 [157]. The analysis demonstrated that eight distinct factors with eigenvalues higher than 1 and the largest factor accounted for 34.54 % of the total variance and less than half, indicating common method bias was likely not a serious threat. Second, The marker-variable test results showed that the coefficients were nearly consistent with the initial estimates (showed in Table C1). Therefore, we concluded that common method bias was not a serious issue in our study.

Table C1
Marker variable tests.

Path coefficients	Research model without the marker variable	Research model with the marker variable
Independent variables		
SFP→TRI	0.386**	0.385**
CFP→TRI	0.289**	0.290**
CFP→TRP	0.232**	0.231**
PFP→TRP	0.196**	0.196**
TRI→TRP	0.527**	0.528**
TRI→PI	0.269**	0.268**

(continued on next page)

Table C1 (*continued*)

Path coefficients	Research model without the marker variable	Research model with the marker variable
TRP→PI	0.493**	0.493**
SFP→PI	-0.046	-0.046
CFP→PI	0.229**	0.230**
PFP→PI	-0.029	-0.029
Control variables		
Age→PI	0.006(N.S.)	-0.006(N.S.)
Gender→PI	-0.044(N.S.)	-0.044(N.S.)
Education→PI	0.012(N.S.)	0.012(N.S.)
Use experience→PI	0.016(N.S.)	0.017(N.S.)
Use duration→PI	0.019(N.S.)	0.019(N.S.)
Use frequency→PI	0.045(N.S.)	0.045(N.S.)
Satisfaction with the previous purchase→PI	0.055(N.S.)	0.055(N.S.)
Influencers' Number of followers→ PI	0.010(N.S.)	0.010(N.S.)
Marker variable		
Marker variable→TRI	–	0.024(N.S.)
Marker variable→TRP	–	-0.009(N.S.)
Marker variable→PI	–	-0.005(N.S.)

Notes: $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, N.S.: non-significant, two-tailed test. SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention.

Appendix D. Post-hoc analysis of Study 2

Table D1
Structural model results.

		Model 1 Direct model			Model 2 Moderation model		
		TRI	TRP	PI	TRI	TRP	PI
Self-focused presentation (SFP)		0.308**	-0.198*	-0.040	0.308**	-0.199*	-0.088
		(0.004)	(0.013)	(0.595)	(0.004)	(0.013)	(0.225)
Consumer-focused presentation (CFP)		0.254*	0.254**	0.228*	0.252*	0.253**	0.192*
		(0.016)	(0.001)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.001)	(0.033)
Product-focused presentation (PFP)		0.149	0.291*	-0.034	0.150	0.298*	-0.018
		(0.249)	(0.017)	(0.664)	(0.246)	(0.017)	(0.814)
Trust in influencers (TRI)			0.574**	0.272*		0.572**	0.332**
			(0.000)	(0.010)		(0.000)	(0.001)
Trust in products (TRP)				0.491**			0.472**
				(0.000)			(0.000)
Gender				-0.044			-0.034
				(0.293)			(0.413)
Control variables	Age			0.006			-0.022
				(0.878)			(0.509)
	Education			0.011			0.026
				(0.792)			(0.549)
	Use Experience			0.017			0.022
				(0.719)			(0.663)
	Use duration			0.018			0.000
				(0.785)			(0.995)
	Use frequency			0.045			0.056
				(0.480)			(0.381)
	Satisfaction with the previous purchase			0.055			0.056
				(0.188)			(0.190)
	Influencers' number of followers			0.010			-0.002
				(0.823)			(0.963)
Interactions	Gender*TRI						0.198**
							(0.006)
	Gender*TRP						-0.179*
							(0.021)
R^2		33.2 %	62.1 %	68.1 %	33.1 %	62.1 %	69.8 %

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention. $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, two-tailed test. Standardized path coefficients with p-values in parentheses.

Table D2
Mediation test results.

Mediation path	Indirect effects	Bias-corrected 95 % Confidence intervals (CIs)	
SFP→TRI→PI	0.084	0.020	0.204
SFP→TRI→TRP→PI	0.087	0.027	0.185
SFP→TRP→PI	-0.097	-0.188	-0.032
CFP→TRI→PI	0.069	0.012	0.161
CFP→TRI→TRP→PI	0.072	0.017	0.154
CFP→TRP→PI	0.125	0.031	0.261
PFP→TRI→PI	0.041	-0.011	0.153
PFP→TRI→TRP→PI	0.042	-0.019	0.171
PFP→TRP→PI	0.143	0.063	0.275

Notes: SFP: Self-Focused Presentation; CFP: Consumer-Focused Presentation; PFP: Product-Focused Presentation; TRI: Trust in Influencers; TRP: Trust in Products; PI: Purchase Intention.

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